

At times, you may come across OEM OSes being offered in the grey market at lower rates. Though they appear to be genuine software with proper license keys, they have to be used with the hardware they were originally meant for. If you buy a PC or a laptop without an OS, then you can buy it online or get it from your local Microsoft partner by simply calling them. In either case you will get a license for your personal use. For e.g. typically when only a single copy is ordered you get the software packed in a box and hence it is termed as Box license. This license is valid for only a single machine which means you can only install it on one computer.

But most offices have more than one computer, for such scenarios, volume licensing should be considered. Most vendors specify the minimum amount of licenses one needs to order before their request is considered for volume licensing. Under volume licensing, you can just buy a single copy of that particular software and install it on as many computers you have. For every computer you install it on your vendor provides you a paper license. If you have 100 computers then you need to possess 100 paper licenses but you need not buy 100 software boxes just a single box would do. When you buy any software it is often validated by entering a code often known as serial key. Under volume licensing you only get one serial key to be used across 100 computers; this saves lot of administrative trouble.

When opting for volume licensing, always think forwards. Today, your office might have just 20 computers, but if you expect it to grow to say 50, it is advisable to buy 50 licenses before hand. This is because the more licenses you buy at once, the better your bargaining power. Also, keep a look out for combo deals. If you are buying OSes, it's likely that you will need to buy office productivity suites such as MS Office as well. If this is so, ask for combo deals. Getting deals on software purchases are very easy in India, because we are so used to not paying for software in India, that vendors and dealers are eager to sell, even at lower prices. Bargain hard, they will give in.

When it comes to server operating systems, there is yet another type of license, often known as Client Access License (CAL). Here the licenses depend on the number of clients that would connect to the server. So, in our case we need 100 CAL to be on the safe side. For small offices, this could mean heavy investment, and Open Source alternatives are welcome.

Alternatives, such as Linux as server operating system workout great in the longer run. Not only will you save money but Linux on a server is a more robust solution. RedHat, SuSE, Mandrake, Ubuntu etc are some of the distribution you can get for the server side. Ubuntu, which is a rage nowadays, also has a special server edition called

LTS (Long Term Support), which, as the name suggests, are kept alive for longer periods before a new version is released thus ensuring stability over longer period.

Productivity

At some point in time, everyone uses word processors, spreadsheets, presentation applications and some database application. Microsoft's Office is the most widely used office productivity suite in the world, and it completely deserves the credit. Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Access are often used, but not everyone may use all these applications in their profession—hence Microsoft offers eight editions of its favourite suite.

If you only need Word, Excel and Outlook (e-mail client) then MS Office Basic 2007 is the way to go. Microsoft Office Standard 2007 comes with all the three in Basic plus PowerPoint and that should be enough for most offices. These two editions are more than enough for any small office; you need not look into the remaining six editions. Licensing is similar to Microsoft's Operating system as described earlier, and volume licensing is also available for Office products.

If you have limited budget, then MS Office might not work out in your favour. In such a case, you can definitely opt for Open Source office applications such as OpenOffice.org. This open source office is very similar to MS office in terms of user interface and has nearly all the features you need. People who swear by Excel initially may have some difficulties working with Calc (Excel alternative), but persistence pays rich dividend. My advice would be to begin with OpenOffice, if things don't work out get Microsoft office.

Accounting department needs more than just office application for keeping track of daily expenses and I would recommend investing in proper accounting software. Tally is well known in the accounting circle and I would recommend it for two reasons; first, it is good and second every fresh commerce graduate coming out of college ensures to learn Tally and hence competent work force is available easily. There is other good Accounting software available too, for example from Wingsinfo.net, who has wider range of products to choose from but then staff training will be required. Most of these accounting software are available as single user license but if you want to deploy it across your accounting team then Multi-user license will be required. A single user license copy can be bought for no more than 10K—no really expensive for something which will help manage assets worth lacs.

Every office creates some kind of database be it customers, clients, subscribers or just simple inventory. Every office needs a good database to ensure business runs smoothly. Microsoft's Access can be used to good effect for creating small but powerful databases and it wouldn't cost you a